

On TikTok and the popular pleasures of digital culture

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Introduction

The short-video app TikTok has taken the world by storm. Despite only being available internationally for a few years, it has already been downloaded more than 2 billion times and 800 million active monthly users. This has made it one of the most downloaded apps of the last decade (SensorTower 2020). Due to this rapid growth, there is little evidence available yet on what makes the app appealing to so many people. Because of this condition, accounts of technologically determinist reasoning on TikTok and its 'addictive' algorithm have come to flourish in pieces of public commentary with headlines such as "How TikTok holds our attention" (Tolentino 2019), "I spent a week on TikTok and all I got was a new phone addiction" (Spanos 2019), or "Digital crack cocaine: The science behind TikTok's success" (Koetsier 2020).

In contrast to this public commentary, early and emerging scholarship on TikTok has thus far taken a much more person-centred and bottom-up approach towards the platform and meaningfulness of communication on it (compare most notably Abidin 2020, Literat and Kligler-Vilenchick 2019, Rettberg 2017, or Siles and Meléndez-Moran 2021). In this paper I seek to contribute to this emerging body of scholarship by responding to the lack of foundational and user perspectives on TikTok. In particular, reporting from a year-long ethnographic investigation of young adult TikTok users in the UK, I discuss what made the app appealing to them. Outlining this appeal as TikTok affording an experience of escapism and ontological security, the paper will reflect on the (de)valuation of seemingly shallow and simple forms of entertainment, like TikTok, in the context of digital cultures.

Fieldwork and Methods

Fieldwork took place over the course of roughly one year, starting in mid-2020. During that period, a series of semi-structured interviews was conducted with 30 young adult users of the TikTok app. Most of them were students or recent graduates and all of them based in the UK at the time of fieldwork. In addition, a digital ethnography of the TikTok platform and other online spaces, like Twitter, to which TikTok content had been shared, was carried out. The interviews were centred around understanding people's uses of TikTok in everyday life, interactions with the TikTok algorithm, and evaluations of the TikTok platform and content. The aim of the digital ethnography was to get a sensibility and deeper understanding for people's reported experiences of consuming TikTok content and interactions with the TikTok algorithm.

Other than presenting a full report of this ethnography, in this paper I focus on the question of what made TikTok appealing to people. Herein my analytical process was guided by the concepts of remediation (Bolter and Grusin 1999) and polymedia (Madianou and Miller 2012). Following the concept of polymedia, I examined TikTok as part of an integrated structure of communicative affordances people draw on to

tackle the various needs they encounter in their everyday life. Following the concept of remediation, TikTok and people's uses of the app were discussed in reference to prior media and forms of mediation it appears a continuation of. In other words, in this paper I make sense of TikTok not as such but in the relative terms of my participants conditions of everyday life and media use.

Popular pleasures: creating distance

The initial rounds of interviews took place in the Summer of 2020. Most of the young adults participating in my project had picked up TikTok during the start of the pandemic and at this point used the app for at least a few of months. Many, however, had already been using the app for longer, joining the platform in 2019 or even earlier. During these initial interviews it became evident that the key reason why they used TikTok was to create distance. Be it distance from the grim realities of the pandemic and lockdown life, to avoid social obligations and pressures, or simply to escape the unbearableness of boredom. The points at which TikTok appeared appealing, and in return people ended up on the app, always came back to being situations and appearances of the 'here and now' that left people empty and somewhat dissatisfied. Moments of anxiety, stress, and boredom whose frequency and intensity many experienced amplified during the pandemic.

The specific feature behind TikTok's appeal in response to such affective states was the For You Page. The For You Page is the algorithmically personalised content feed sitting at the heart of the app's design. It displays people with an endless array of short-video clips only a few seconds in length. For outside observers, this assemblage of video clips often appears random. An array of simple and shallow entertainments made addictive by algorithmic means. However, for my participants this ephemerality of contents and 'ordinary strangers' they encountered by scrolling through the For You Page rendered it something appealing. One of my participants, Judith, described this appeal as the For You Page offering a distanced yet intimate view on life. "It's just like seeing what your friends are up to if your friends were all kind of cool and you didn't have any obligation to them." (Judith).

All of my participants at one point formulated similar descriptions of their For You Page. For them it always felt like something that is 'close to home' and 'relatable', something that is "just easy to use, something that you don't have to think about." (Iris). While other platforms also use algorithmic personalisation, TikTok was described to be exceptionally good at it. Scrolling through the app was something easily enjoyable, as Iris and other participants stated, because you don't have to think about. It simply is 'ready-to-hand'. The flow of videos assembled on the For You Page resonated with people without there being the need for focussed and isolated interpretation of contents. It presents people with a view on life not as it is but how it could and possibly should be. An appearance of life that they knew and appeals to

them, yet they might not necessarily experience themselves once putting their phone down.

The desire for escaping reality did herein, however, not just stem from senses of dissatisfaction with the everyday as such but also the broader media landscape. For example, Twitter and Instagram were platforms that my participants did also use very frequently. However, Twitter for many evoked and reproduced a certain sense of anxiety and stress. As I was told, being on the Twitter for too long one can easily end up in a dark place surrounded only by commentary on how bad things are going in the world at the moment. On Instagram people often experienced heightened sense of boredom and social obligation. A platform on which platform people normally consume content from either friends or 'follow famous' people and celebrities. Concerning the former element, people felt that less and less interesting content had been posted by their friends because everyone was at home in lockdown. That content which still emerged on the platform being consumed less for entertainment than fulfilling social obligations of maintaining relations. Concerning the latter element, especially during the pandemic people felt that the content of celebrities and creators felt out of touch. This, in consequence, intensifying a longer standing dissatisfaction with an 'inauthenticity' characterising Instagram content.

In sum, TikTok was appealing to my participants not just because it offered them a relief from experiences of the 'here and now' leaving them empty. Much rather, it also offered people an escape within their polymedia environments otherwise too appearing experientially grey. In distinction to other apps, TikTok seems to address a desire to have an online space for the self, public yet intimate, freed from social obligation. One of my participants, Bea, explained what set TikTok apart from other online spaces in the following way: "When I go on TikTok I can just watch videos of cute dogs and stuff. It's more of an escape than Twitter or Instagram for me, especially right now ... just a nice way to avoid life. On TikTok time is kind of paused. It's like a true 30-minute escape." (Bea).

Ontological security and everyday routines

TikTok, of course, is similar in its design to other social media platforms. It allows people to create profiles, follow other users, create videos, or interact with one another. However, most of my participants didn't use TikTok for these kind of activities primarily. Instead, it was a more 'passive' consumption of content, a kind of mindless scrolling and consciously getting distracted, that they looked for. In this regard, the descriptions of why and how my participants used TikTok didn't really resonate with present literatures on social media. Much rather, strong similarities emerged with earlier scholarship of popular media forms like soap operas (e.g. Ang 1985) or magazines (e.g. Hermes 1995).

As a media form, the For You Page, obviously, has vastly different structural properties than a soap opera. There is no single narrative that one follows and there is no fixed set of characters who's development one can get invested in. And even though TikTok could offer such a narrative structure to some degree, through enabling people to follow specific creators, my participants said that they didn't really act on that possibility. Instead, they preferred For You Page and its mediation of ephemeral yet still intimate encounters with 'ordinary strangers' sharing bits out of their daily life. Even though in different form, it is here that TikTok and its For You Page, curating those bits into a meaningful flow of content 'for you', seems to remediate the kind of popular pleasures of identification and emotional realism that Ien Ang (1985) has outlined as characteristic for genres such as the soap opera.

The settings, situations, and characters of a soap opera like *Dallas* often resembled the very conditions of everyday life that its viewers themselves lived in. An appearance of life, however, with a spin to it. For the case of soap operas that being melodramatic, as Ang (1985) showed, framing otherwise mundane everyday situations as highly emotional and significant life events. A fictional representation of everyday life that, for viewers invested into it, is experienced as emotionally real. Similarly, scrolling through TikTok my participants experienced a similar form of emotional realism. On their For You Page they would see content of 'ordinary strangers' like them. Serendipitous and fleeting encounters programmed by TikTok's algorithms observing and reinforcing past viewing habits. Encounters in the form of content geared not towards providing an in-depth look into other people's lives. Instead, content part of a bigger flow, the For You Page, presenting people with a curated view on life. For my participants one that was mostly comedic, joyful, wholesome, and aesthetically pleasing in its overall form.

Neither fictional nor 'objective' account of the present moment, it is the access to this algorithmically curated 'structure of feeling', particular quality of social and human experience (Williams 1977), that made TikTok appealing to people. Appealing especially for reasons similar to those that scholars like Roger Silverstone (1994) have discussed alongside the concept of 'ontological security' for practices of watching television. Ontological security here meaning the human desire for life to be consistent and governed by some kind of order (Giddens 1991). Similar to television, TikTok provided people with such a sense of ontological security in the combination of both its contents and routines of consumption. The content of TikTok itself provided an outlook on life that reassured my participants that it, somewhere and for someone, still is in order. In return, the regular consumption of such content stabilising senses of ontological security over time. Routines whose importance was amplified during the pandemic. As one of my participants, Josh, explained: "In this time people need something like that to encourage them to go on and keep on." (Josh).

TikTok providing this emotional reassurance doesn't make it something 'new'. It 'merely' continues a lineage of popular media forms, like soap operas, that have and

do provide people with this kind of reassurance. However, TikTok appears distinct from such previous audio-visual forms in that it shares with magazines the quality of being 'putdownable'. As Joke Hermes (1995) has outlined in her study on readers of women's magazines, a key appeal of magazines was that they could be easily picked up and put down again. They do not require the coordination alongside a broadcasting schedule or demand a set amount of time for a story to unfold. Instead, magazines, and likewise TikTok, are flexible in their use. They can easily respond to whatever situational need for the pleasures of escapism one faces.

As a mobile phone app, being flexible in that way, TikTok often ended up being integrated into various broader rhythms of everyday life. Mostly being used in situations such as waking up and getting the day started, after work trying to unwind, or lying in bed before falling asleep. It is in these situations, not setting but supplementing the rhythms of everyday life, that TikTok seemed to matter to my participants the most. As one of my them, Sunder, elaborated: "I don't remember if I had been working already when we last spoke, but I'm working full-time in a supermarket right now. I think this has made me really appreciate this kind of mindlessly scrolling ... I think there is something that really helps me at the end of the day to just watch small chunks of stuff." (Sunder).

More than just TikTok

In sum, TikTok appeared appealing to my participants for affording the creation of distance and experience of ontological reassurance. Two properties that aren't unique to TikTok as a popular media form. Yet properties that still set it apart from what other social media platforms have at offer right now. So do the stories of the young adults I worked with and does the app's explosive growth suggest. However, in being this kind of 'online feel good space', TikTok also seemed to fall short in being seen as something meaningful. While all of my participants said that they enjoyed being on TikTok, some also said things like: "TikTok is just dumb. There is nothing meaningful about it necessarily. For most of us ... we're just watching it and passing time." (Rosa).

As Ang reminds us, "entertainment is usually associated with simple, uncomplicated pleasure ... nothing is less true, however." (1985: 19). People tend to describe media like TikTok as 'mere entertainments' because they are something self-evident to them. They have to be, because that is their whole point, to 'just' be entertaining, fun, or emotionally reassuring without people having to think about them. Yet that doesn't make them less complex, or their consequences less of an achievement. The issue that TikTok raises, I argue, is that which has already been discussed for decades in relation to other and prior 'mere entertainments' like soap operas or magazines. That is the issue in which we grapple with this complexity and valuation of those 'mere entertainments' that make people feel better in their daily life.

At various different stages throughout my fieldwork I encountered this issue of valuation. Both the young adults of my project yet also public commentary often sought in their discussion of TikTok for it to be something more than 'just TikTok', than 'just' being emotionally reassuring. Neoliberal imperatives of productivity in particular were noticeably at work in the reasoning of my participants. Some, in fact, had stated that the key reason why they participated in my project was because they felt a certain sense of guilt for being on TikTok and doing nothing else. As one of them, Joyce, explained why she responded to my call for participants: "I thought 'this is the most productive thing I'll ever have to do with TikTok' ... so I felt a bit better about myself for using it so much" (Joyce).

Similarly, in public and intellectual debates it appeared that TikTok was deemed worth attention only once it touched on more 'serious topics' such as politics, the public sphere, or the economic opportunity it holds. Simply, something more than 'just' making people feel good. That is not to say these aren't relevant aspects of the app. Many of my participants were very aware about the geopolitical entanglements of TikTok, the possibility for it to be used in political discourses and activism, or that it as an app and some creators on it have to make money from the app. Yet issues arise when the value of popular media like TikTok is defined through the lens of such more 'serious topics' first and foremost. A pressure to do so which, as David Morley (2015) has more recently emphasised, also again comes to shape reasoning in fields of media and communication studies.

The hope, we might conclude, that emerges from TikTok's lockdown popularity is that it, and other popular media forms, become part of the broader re-evaluations of practices of care that have started to emerge during the pandemic (compare Chatzidakis et al. 2020). For what TikTok achieves today already for people like the young adults I worked with should be enough in itself to render it meaningful as a medium. A meaningfulness that becomes easily evident when thinking in non-media-centric ways and terms of 'polymedia', shifting analytical attention to the question of why, when, and how people choose to engage with some media over others (Madianou and Miller 2012).

TikTok and its design obviously afford myriad forms of communicative engagement. That my participants didn't engage with TikTok to, for example, participate in public debates or do something 'productive' is, therefore, ultimately a choice they make repeatedly. A choice, however, which does not mean that their engagement with all media is uniform along that line. Quite on the contrary, precisely because other platforms like Twitter already had come to occupy and fulfil certain desires for public engagement, TikTok appears appropriated to match an area of people's identity work that other platforms seemed unable to sufficiently deliver on. That is the desire for momentarily creating distance to the 'here and now' and experiencing a sense of ontological security in everyday life.

That is to say, taking seriously popular media like TikTok is a question of tracing the reasons why and ways in which they are used, how they are made to matter in people's lives. The tools to do so, to understand why and how new media like TikTok matter to people, do already exist. The contribution of this paper is thus not the development of novel arguments and concepts but rather to reiterate the importance of existing analytical repertoires capable of taking seriously the taken-for-grantedness of 'mere entertainments' like TikTok. That is because far too often phenomena like TikTok, while enjoyed by many, still remain poorly understood and devalued in the same way that magazines, soap operas, and other 'guilty pleasures' and 'pastimes' have been before.

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